The idea of developing a *modus vivendi* with Moscow that provided for the management of relations between Washington and Moscow was exactly the kind of pragmatism in foreign policy that John F, Kennedy had sought. It was very much in keeping with the superpower détente pursued by Richard Nixon and Leonid Brezhnev. And just as the 1971 agreement put German reunification on hold, the strategic arms agreements of the SALT process sought to manage rather than eliminate nuclear weapons. It took Mikhail Gorbachev to precipitate the reunification of Germany (and the collapse of the Warsaw Pact, as well as the USSR). But his policies did not precipitate global nuclear disarmament that he sought (any more than Ronald Reagan succeeded in making nuclear weapons 'impotent and obsolete').

When Leonid Brezhnev became General Secretary in 1964, a nascent détente had developed momentum. A more stable and predictable relationship between East and West ensued (though one insufficiently stable and predictable to prevent Soviet attacks on Czechoslovakia and later Afghanistan, or US attacks on North Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia).

Nothing to see here

In 1972 the Chinese Premier, Zhou Enlai, was asked about the impact of the French Revolution in 1789-99. He replied that it was 'too early to say'. For some, this made him the Chinese Communist Party's answer to Oscar Wilde (for others it illustrated how China always looked to the long game). In fact, it seems there was a mistranslation or misunderstanding and Zhou thought he was being asked about the student-led protests in Paris in 1968. Nevertheless, the idea that events may have significant impacts over many years, and which remain unnoticed for many years, is worth pondering. So, Berlin aside, what was the impact of the Cuban missile crisis? Some important consequences can be identified. But a case can also be made that the moment when humanity faced its 'greatest threat in thousands of years' had surprisingly limited effect on global politics.

The resolution of the crisis helped create a context and impetus for several arms control agreements. There was progress toward a 'hot line' (as